

Architectural styles

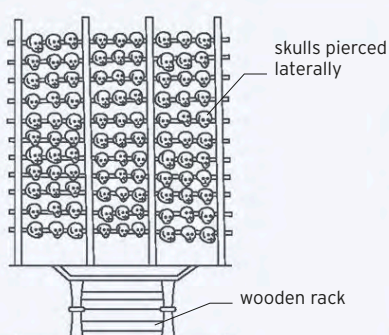
PRE-COLUMBIAN AMERICA

Pre-Columbian refers to all of the indigenous civilizations that occupied the Americas prior to the arrival of Europeans in the 15th century. The most significant in terms of the architecture they produced were the Mesoamerican cultures.

Mesoamerica is the historic area extending from central Mexico in the north to Costa Rica in the south. It was home to a number of major cultures, such as the Olmec, Zapotec, Aztec, and Maya, who developed their own forms of mathematics, writing, astronomy, religion—and architecture.

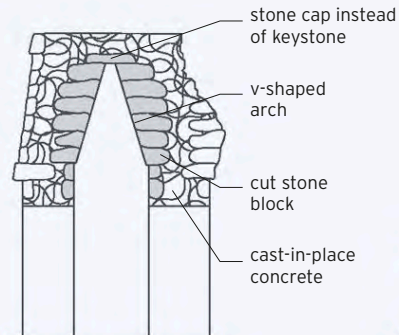
The stepped pyramid is the most distinctive building of Mesoamerican architecture. Unlike Egyptian pyramids, Mesoamerican pyramids did not contain burials but acted as temples, raised up toward the stars. They were a key part of the way these cultures conceived architecture as acting as the interface between the human world and the afterlife. This was also manifested in the layout of cities; temples looked out across great plazas, along with palaces and ball courts for the ritual games common to many Mesoamerican cultures. Residences and ceremonial structures were often built in separate areas of the city to create a distinction between the everyday and religious functions of the city. In some cultures, certain buildings were also aligned with the positions of stars and other objects in the sky at particular times of year.

SYMBOLIC STRUCTURES



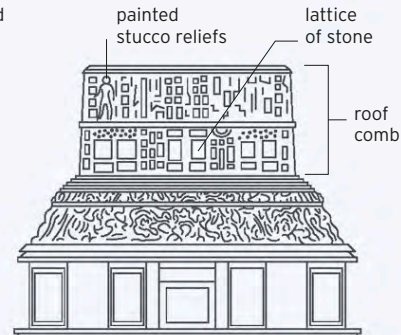
△ TZOMPANTLI SKULL DISPLAY

Found across several Mesoamerican civilizations, the *tzompantli* is a rack containing rows of human skulls. The skulls typically belonged to vanquished foes or victims of human sacrifice.



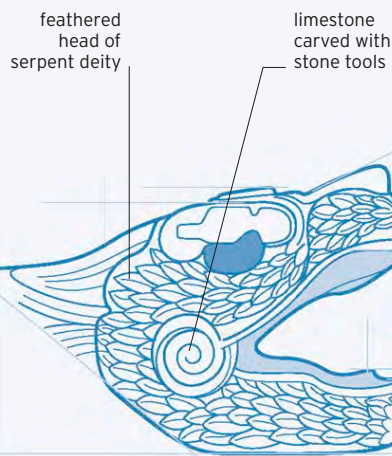
△ MAYA ARCH

Maya craftsmen used a kind of corbeled arch formed from adjacent overhanging tiers of masonry. They combined stone blocks with concrete that was cast within the stone structure.



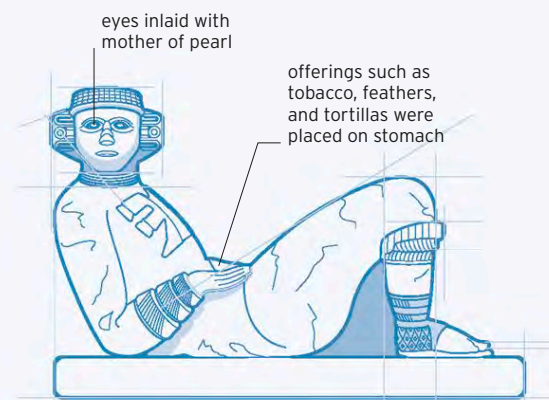
△ ROOF COMB

Many Mesoamerican pyramids were topped with a structure called a roof comb that served to increase the pyramid's height and to display decoration and iconography.



△ SERPENT STATUES AND MOTIFS

The serpent was an important symbol in Maya culture and is a frequent motif in sculpture. At El Castillo, shadows cast at the equinoxes make the serpent appear to undulate down the staircase.



△ CHAC-MOOL STATUE

This statue, common in Mesoamerican cultures, depicts a reclining man holding a bowl on his torso. It is thought to symbolize a fallen warrior carrying an offering to the gods.

52 panels on each side of pyramid represent number of years in a Maya sacred cycle called a Calendar Round

stone serpent head

serpent shadow cast here at spring and fall equinoxes

▲ EL CASTILLO, CHICHÉN ITZÁ

Chichén Itzá was a large city located in what is now Yucatán, Mexico, built by the Maya from around the 7th century CE. The centerpiece of the city complex is the limestone El Castillo stepped pyramid, topped by a temple and accessed from four external stairways.